'Dan, please stop,' I said. 'That's Ernie Els, and I want to meet this guy. He's been my ultimate hero for as long as I can remember. You carry on. I'll be home in five minutes, or so.'

I walked towards where he had parked. His wife and children were already heading into the house, and he must have looked up and seen me approaching from around 20 metres.

'AB, you *bliksem*!' he shouted, with a grin.

'Hi,' I said. 'I just wanted to say hello.'

'Yes, it's great to see you,' he replied. 'We're going to have a beer. Come in.'

He had some American friends, Kevin and Ira, staying with him and Ernie introduced me to them as 'South Africa's Babe Ruth', adding that they could stuff baseball because cricket was a much better game. The Americans seemed to get the idea, and, over a few beers, we all chatted cheerfully for a while, about golf and cricket, baseball and sport in general.

'Let's play golf tomorrow,' Ernie announced. 'I'll arrange a tee-off time at Oubaai.'

'That would be great,' I said, trying to appear only moderately interested in the idea, when, in truth, I was unbelievably excited. Soon, I was also very scared of embarrassing myself because my golf game has declined a little in recent years, ever since my peak when I was 23. I hadn't really had time to play and, when I had managed to get on the course, I had struggled to keep the ball on the fairway. Oh well, I thought, I can't let this opportunity pass. I will try my best.

Oubaai golf club is a beautiful links course, located between the Indian Ocean and the Outeniqua Mountains, designed by Ernie, and, at very short notice, I asked a friend, Jan Potgieter, to be my partner in what would be a special four-ball.

Ernie was six under par after the first nine holes, and we were well down but, to my great relief, I was striking the ball well off the tee ... and